

Identical Zero and 1st Conditional

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(Brazil) Ariyañāṇa Bhikkhu

The zero conditional, when with a modal, looks **identical** to the 1st Conditional structure.

Structural Comparison

	Purpose	Formula	Example
Zero	General facts, habits, rules	If + Present + Present	<i>If I win, you come.</i>
		If + Present + Modal	<i>If I win, you can come.</i>
First	Specific future outcome	If + Present + Future	<i>If I win, you will come.</i>
		If + Present + Imperative	<i>If I win, come.</i>
		If + Present + Modal	<i>If I win, you can come.</i>

When modal verbs (must, can, should, may, have to) are introduced, they replace standard verb tenses and blur the line between zero and first conditionals.

Both zero and first conditionals can be made with Present + Modal: *If I win, you **can come**.*

- If this sentence refers to a situation that **always happens**, it is the **zero** conditional, meaning: Every time I win, you can always come.

- If it refers to a **specific future situation**, it is the first conditional, meaning: If I win (tomorrow), you can come (at that time tomorrow).

In order to identify which is the case, look at the **context**.

Further Examples

1. Can (Ability / Permission)

- **Zero Conditional (General Rule):**

If you have a library card, you **can** borrow books.

- **First Conditional (Specific Future):**

If you pass your test tomorrow, you **can** borrow my car.

2. Should (Advice / Recommendation)

- **Zero Conditional (General Advice):**

If it rains, you **should** wear a coat.

- **First Conditional (Future Advice):**

If it rains this afternoon, you **should** take an umbrella.

3. Have to (Obligation)

- **Zero Conditional (General Duty):**

If the alarm goes off, everyone **has to** evacuate.

- **First Conditional (Future Duty):**

If the alarm goes off during our meeting later, we **have to** leave immediately.